



DIALECTICAL DILEMMA: Karat and Bardhan with the prime minister; (below) Manmohan Singh with BJP's Atal Bihari Vajpayee



SIPRA DAS

Vajpayee's historic achievement.

Just when it looked the prime minister had bought himself some breathing space, he faced further embarrassment from an unexpected quarter: the US. Late Wednesday, a state department official declared that if India tested a nuclear device, the agreement would be scrapped. While technically, this was one of the clauses in the fine print of the 123 agreement, it is somewhat ambiguous since the Indian side insists it has every right to conduct a test (*see following story*). The devil may well lie in the details but for the Prime Minister, facing an increasingly belligerent Left, it was the last thing he needed. Armed with fresh ammunition, the deal came under fire again in Parliament on Thursday. Manmohan was not allowed to speak in either house. Instead it was the external affairs minister, Pranab Mukherjee who tabled a statement in the house, which simply stated that "the Government asserts its right to conduct nuclear tests despite the deal with the US". The Left staged a walk out but Manmohan seems to have taken a decision to stick to his tough stance. For once the Congress is standing solidly behind him, even though privately most of them wish he had stood firm on economic reforms rather than an issue most of them have a problem in relating to. Also, Congressmen are worried as most recall that in the fragile era of coalition rule even a small incident can topple governments. And clearly the question of India's sovereignty makes for a more volatile issue than two Haryana constables being accused of spying on a leader of Opposition (Rajiv Gandhi) in 1991 which brought down the then Government.

Interestingly, the Left has been ignoring the UNPA's appeal to join forces. Although Third Front parties like the SP and TDP would have liked to align with the Left against the Congress, the Left wants the fight to be exclusive. It is a fight in which it has to deal directly with the prime minister, not the UPA chairperson. And Manmohan has never been a favourite of the Marxists. When he was finance minister in the Narasimha Rao cabinet, the Left had singled him out as a capitalist usurper. In 1992, the Left and BJP came together to stall the proceedings of the Lok